

The Culture Problem: *Chike Jeffers and Cultural Supremacy*

The social sciences often have difficulty differentiating necessary qualities from sufficient ones – a problem that becomes especially acute in discussions of race. While seemingly innocuous, such ambiguities stymie productive discussions of race through vague attempts at establishing universal definitions for subjective conditions. Such attempts may be more representative of a philosopher's inclination toward a specific topic than a commitment to advancing knowledge. This is the case in Chike Jeffers' work on cultural constructionism – the attempt to explain culture's effect on social conditions. Jeffers claims that if systems of racial oppression are dissolved, culture is not dismantled alongside race; it persists. He then argues that such a hypothetical world would merely substitute racial division for cultural division – and the same material disparities would remain. This distinction rests on Jeffers's implicit assumption that humans are inherently hierarchical. Proper analysis of social conditions, however, recognizes the materials that allow the enforcement of division. Accordingly, a more precise definition of culture would reconcile the personal with the material. Heuristics – pieces of information used in decision-making or problem-solving – are the sufficient conditions for culture, not matters of regional supremacy.

Jeffers's approach conflates race and culture by proposing that, while culture and race are separate, they are regionally identifiable and are likely geographically connected. This relationship is not dependent, however, as his understanding of culture is a collection of ideals and group priorities, which persist even as biological characteristics are diluted. These dilutions are recognizable in cultural diasporas, especially for the mixed individuals that maintain their learned culture. Considering the lack of clarity from Jeffers on a pure cultural definition, and

given the material impacts of the conclusions drawn in this discussion, a definition that unites the personal and the material is necessary.

Culture as Heuristics:

Through a materialist framework, culture can be defined as a set of geographically relevant social and environmental heuristics. Heuristics are rules or pieces of information that enable problem-solving or decision-making. These pieces of information are often gained through social conditioning. At humanity's most basic state, information from predator-prey, personal-environmental, and interpersonal relationships creates patterns for humans to observe and adopt. This basic analysis explains why societies in hotter areas develop preferences for spicy foods. Spicy foods cause sweat, and sweat cools people down; as people in hot areas need to cool down in order to thrive – as per their need to maintain homeostasis – spicy food becomes a necessary addition to the environment. This pattern is found naturally through observation and repetition, and is then passed down in the form of tradition. Tradition, then, is a set of rules based on the historical interpretation, within a given community, of what activities, beliefs, and behaviors are necessary in order to thrive in a given environment. While only a microcosm of culture, tradition here serves as a necessary test case for the many aspects that make up the common realities of culture. Humans are many things, but above all, they are social creatures that survive based on accumulated knowledge.

Though the interpretation of culture as heuristics is understandable, it is fair to object to its false exhaustivity. Jeffers himself argues that culture has evolved beyond basic survival instincts. From a modern perspective, technology allows humans to pursue goals beyond survival, and this allowance permits the development of “the arts.” An example of such cultural activity is the Islamic practice of wearing hijabs, some of which may be dark and can cause heat

stroke in deserts – this exists in spite of, not because of, the natural environment. These circumstances broadly fall under Jeffers’s interpretation of culture. Despite this, a more accurate assessment of culture – in a discussion of structural supremacy – may instead involve a carveout of art. Art, then, refers to expressions of shared or individual identity. Such messages may intend to persuade; some may protest; in some cases, art may merely exist for its own sake. Images and manifestations of items that exist for their own sake are not unique to people. As seen in the Romantic period, artists themselves have recognized nature as a source of beauty in its own right – even without human intervention. Thus, the recognition of images and manifestations that exist for their own sake may be an inherent quality of consciousness. Since consciousness is present in all humans, it is an inherent quality of humanity. Accordingly, these images, manifestations, or other forms of “art” may be non-unique to discussions of oppression; this is especially valuable considering Jeffers’s prevailing definition of “culture” broadly as a means to divide people based on region. Moreover, this omission demonstrates the validity and importance of applying a materialist framework to an otherwise abstract debate.

A Framework of Supremacy:

With the materialist framework now established, one must critically assess the assumption that hierarchy is inherent to humanity. Jeffers’s framework entrenches differences between people and suggests that mere political redistribution of power would not fix supremacist relationships. If redistributive policy were effectively enacted, then, all else equal, the only explanation for a certain group’s continued claim to power would be inherent superiority. An assessment of “superiority” itself must be established to adequately deconstruct Jeffers’s implication.

Jeffers himself admits the corrosive force of Western imperial influence in his conflated understanding of race and culture, both of which, he acknowledges, are “shaped by the historical force of the modern West’s imperial antagonisms”(pg. 196). It would be unfair, however, to define his argument by this single acknowledgment. Instead, it is necessary to establish the origins of human inequality. The notion of “inherent superiority” is as devastating as it is incoherent. Any notion that follows from such an assumption must define what “superiority” could possibly mean. Superiority could refer to present material conditions, divine ordainment, biological inheritance, or even some vague understanding of “sophistication.”

Jeffers, in his account, appears to subscribe to a model of biological or regionally inherited superiority, which rests on the implicit secondary assumption that genes carry moral value. If genes have moral value, and if morals operate on normative understandings of “good” and “bad,” then it becomes the responsibility of those who act rightly to excise defective genes from the world. This is a logically consistent worldview if those assumptions hold true. One may argue, however, that there is no qualifier for what makes a gene “good” in the first place. Accordingly, such a metric would leave societies scrambling to identify those who merely claim to possess superior genes – ushering in chaos at the behest of biological “purity.” The incestuous progression of essentialist rhetoric is ultimately futile for navigating social philosophy, though it remains crucial to understand the underlying goals of such movements.

Competition in the Cultural Marketplace:

One may argue that nomadic principles of natural preservation – like those practiced by the nomadic Native Americans of the Southwestern U.S. – are antithetical to imperialist supremacist ends. This ideological difference serves as a useful comparison between cultures of exploitation and coexistence.

While one could make normative claims about the ethics, or lack thereof, of imperialist ideology and culture, there is no evidence to suggest that a “culture,” as he puts it, is responsible for material superiority. A much more accurate source for these disparities is the materials themselves, coupled with the recognition of which actors hold and control the means of accessing those materials. Thus, Jeffers’ argument fails to counter the theory that existing structures are not due to culture but, instead – as high school history teachers put it – guns, germs, and steel. These three, notably, are byproducts of acute access to materials rather than chronic cultural conditions.

Disproportionate control of resources, then, is the only dynamic that allows these structures to continue. In a hypothetical world with equal distribution of resources, nothing except inherent intellectual and human capital – denoted by region and environment – would provide the means for imperialist dominance.

Conclusion:

Jeffers uses semantics to establish provisional definitions for culture and race. In doing so, however, he fails to effectively defend “cultural determinism” – a sort of social Darwinism involving an inherent competitive and suppressive component in humanity. In that vein, Jeffers fails to establish hierarchy as inherent to humanity, which leaves room to critique his culturally determinist approach.

Rather than accept cultural determinism – or what Jeffers calls a non-exhaustive cultural constructionism – an alternative is available. Attempting to compartmentalize subjective experiences of self-defense and human evolution into fixed hierarchies may inadvertently support the very structures such frameworks are intended to inhibit. Accordingly, it is the duty of those engaged in such analysis to include material conditions in their understanding of inequality.

In this light, culture may instead appear as environmentally and socially relevant heuristics – with a notable carveout for the distinctly human capacity for art – which grounds discussions of supremacy in material realities rather than abstract cultural essences.